

# Lecture 19: The "S-Curve" (Control Rod Worth, Calibration, and Shadowing)

CBE 30235: Introduction to Nuclear Engineering — D. T. Leighton

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## Introduction: The Misconception of the "Gas Pedal"

In a car, if you press the gas pedal 10% further, you generally expect a proportional increase in engine output. In a nuclear reactor, a Control Rod is **not linear**.

- Moving a rod 1 inch at the **bottom** of the core might add  $\approx 0$  reactivity.
- Moving a rod 1 inch in the **middle** of the core might add huge amounts of reactivity.
- Moving a rod 1 inch at the **top** of the core might add  $\approx 0$  reactivity again.

This non-linearity creates the famous "**S-Curve**" of rod worth. Understanding this curve is vital for predicting how the reactor will respond to operator actions and ensuring the core does not undergo an accidental power excursion.

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## 1 The Physics: Perturbation and Flux Weighting

Why does the rod effectiveness depend heavily on its position? We can explain this using **Perturbation Theory**.

The reactivity effect ( $\rho$ ) of inserting a neutron-absorbing rod depends on two factors:

1. **The Local Flux ( $\phi$ ):** How many neutrons are physically present to be absorbed? If a region has no neutrons, inserting a rod there does nothing.
2. **The Adjoint Flux / Importance ( $\phi^\dagger$ ):** How important is a neutron in that specific location to sustaining the overall chain reaction? In a simple, bare reactor, the "importance" of a location is directly proportional to the flux itself ( $\phi^\dagger \approx \phi$ ).

Therefore, the "worth" of a control rod at a specific axial height  $z$  is proportional to the **square** of the unperturbed flux at that location:

$$\text{Worth}(z) \propto \phi(z)^2 \tag{1}$$

## 2 Differential and Integral Rod Worth

Let's consider a bare cylindrical reactor. The fundamental flux distribution along the vertical height ( $H$ ) is a chopped sine wave:

$$\phi(z) = \phi_{max} \sin\left(\frac{\pi z}{H}\right)$$

## 2.1 Differential Rod Worth ( $\frac{d\rho}{dz}$ )

The Differential Rod Worth tells us how much reactivity we add or subtract *per inch* of rod movement. Based on our squared-flux rule:

$$\frac{d\rho}{dz} = C \sin^2 \left( \frac{\pi z}{H} \right) \quad (2)$$

Where  $C$  is a scaling constant based on the macroscopic absorption cross-section of the rod material (e.g., Boron Carbide, Silver-Indium-Cadmium).

### Physical Interpretation:

- **Core Edges ( $z = 0, H$ ):** The flux approaches zero due to neutron leakage. Moving the rod near the very top or bottom has almost zero effect.
- **Core Center ( $z = H/2$ ):** The flux is at its absolute maximum. The rod is "biting" into the highest population of neutrons. Moving the rod here causes rapid, massive changes in reactivity.

## 2.2 Integral Rod Worth (The S-Curve)

Operators need to know the **Total Reactivity** ( $\rho$ ) inserted if they pull a rod from the fully inserted position ( $z = 0$ ) to a specific withdrawal height ( $z$ ). We find this by integrating the differential worth:

$$\rho(z) = \int_0^z \frac{d\rho}{dz'} dz' = \int_0^z C \sin^2 \left( \frac{\pi z'}{H} \right) dz'$$

Using the trigonometric identity  $\sin^2(\theta) = \frac{1 - \cos(2\theta)}{2}$ , we obtain the integral worth equation:

$$\rho(z) = \rho_{total} \left[ \frac{z}{H} - \frac{1}{2\pi} \sin \left( \frac{2\pi z}{H} \right) \right] \quad (3)$$

This function generates the classic **S-shape** (Sigmoid) curve.

## 3 Core Distortion: Shadowing and Anti-Shadowing

The equations above assume a single rod in a "perfect" unperturbed flux. In reality, multiple rods interact with each other by physically reshaping the neutron flux profile.

- **Flux Depression:** A control rod acts like a black hole for thermal neutrons. The flux immediately surrounding the rod dips significantly.
- **Rod Shadowing:** If Rod A is inserted, it depresses the local flux. If Rod B is located right next to Rod A, Rod B is now sitting in a "neutron shadow." Because worth depends on  $\phi^2$ , the worth of Rod B is *decreased* by the presence of Rod A.
- **Anti-Shadowing:** Conversely, if inserting Rod A pushes the overall core flux to the opposite side of the reactor, a Rod C located on that far side now experiences an artificially high flux. Rod C's worth is *increased* by the presence of Rod A.

To combat flux distortion and shadowing, reactors rarely move single rods. They move rods in symmetric, distributed groups called **Control Banks**.

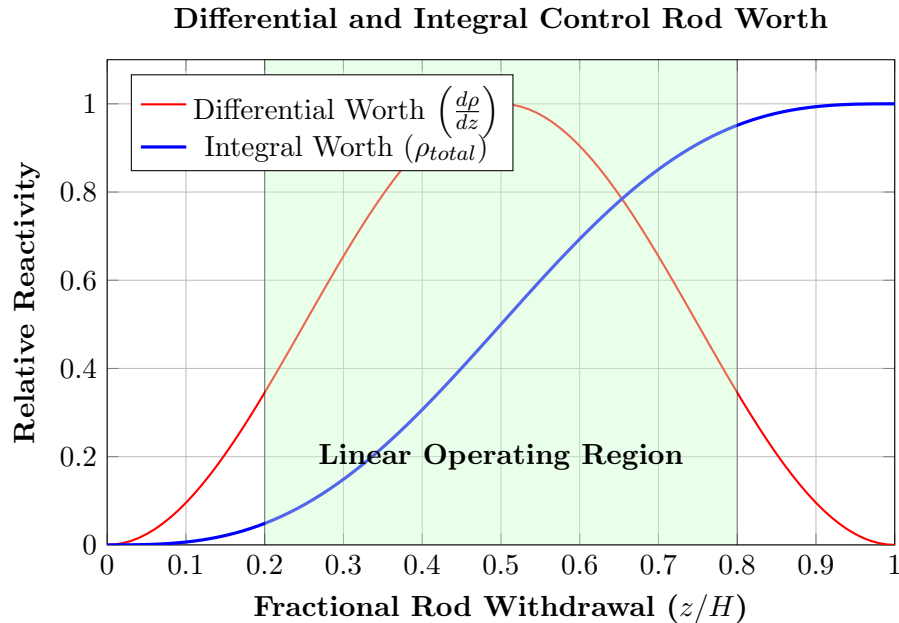


Figure 1: The mathematical relationship between rod position and reactivity. Operators prefer to keep rods in the shaded 20%-80% region where the S-Curve is roughly linear, ensuring predictable reactor response.

## 4 How Do We Measure It? (Rod Calibration)

You cannot just calculate rod worth; it must be experimentally measured for every new core loading. The most common technique is the **Positive Period Method**:

1. Establish critical steady-state at very low power.
2. Withdraw the test rod by a small increment ( $\Delta z$ ). The reactor is now slightly supercritical.
3. Power begins to rise exponentially:  $P(t) = P_0 e^{t/T}$ .
4. Measure the Reactor Period ( $T$ ), which is the time it takes for power to increase by a factor of  $e$ .
5. Use the **Inhour Equation** to convert  $T$  into actual Reactivity ( $\rho$ ).
6. Add boric acid (or insert a different rod bank) to return the reactor to critical, and repeat the process for the next increment.

By summing the  $\Delta\rho$  increments, we physically trace out the S-Curve.

## 5 Safety Implications and the SL-1 Accident

The  $\phi^2$  dependence has terrifying safety implications, famously demonstrated by the **SL-1 accident in 1961**.

The SL-1 was a small military prototype reactor in Idaho. It featured a massive central control rod (#9) that sat at the absolute peak of the radial flux distribution.

- The total delayed neutron fraction ( $\beta$ ) is roughly 0.0065 (or  $0.65\% \Delta k/k$ ). Injecting this amount of reactivity makes a reactor Prompt Critical.
- The central #9 rod in SL-1 was incredibly valuable, worth roughly  $0.04 \Delta k/k$  from top to bottom.
- During a maintenance procedure, an operator was supposed to lift the rod 4 inches (staying in the low-worth bottom tail of the S-curve).
- Due to a stuck mechanism, he manually yanked the rod, inadvertently withdrawing it approximately 20 inches. This pulled the rod straight through the maximum-worth center of the S-curve.
- He injected over  $2\% \Delta k/k$  of reactivity (more than  $3\times$  the prompt critical threshold) in a fraction of a second. The subsequent steam explosion destroyed the vessel and killed the three operators.

**The Legacy - Stuck Rod Criterion:** Modern power reactors are now legally required to be designed such that they will safely shut down (remain subcritical) even if the single most reactive control rod is completely ejected or stuck fully out of the core.

## 6 Control Rod Materials: Engineering Trade-offs

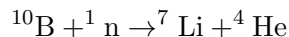
We know a rod needs a high macroscopic absorption cross-section ( $\Sigma_a$ ), but nuclear engineers must also consider physical state, required cladding, lifespan, mechanical swelling, and cost. There is no "perfect" material.

| Material                              | Physical Form                                                  | Pros                                                                                                               | Cons                                                                                                     |
|---------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Boron Carbide</b><br>( $B_4C$ )    | Ceramic pellets. <b>Must be clad</b> in stainless steel.       | Very high thermal $\sigma_a$ . Cheap and lightweight.                                                              | $(n, \alpha)$ reaction produces Helium gas. Causes high internal pressure, requires a hollow gas plenum. |
| <b>Silver-Indium-Cadmium</b><br>(AIC) | Metal Alloy (80/15/5). <b>Must be clad</b> in stainless steel. | Excellent epithermal resonance absorbers. Does not produce gas.                                                    | Heavy, expensive. Soft metal with poor corrosion resistance. Silver activates to Ag-110m (strong gamma). |
| <b>Hafnium</b><br>(Hf)                | Solid Metal. <b>Unclad</b> (Directly exposed to coolant).      | "Chain-absorbing" (isotopes remain absorbers after catching a neutron). Extreme corrosion resistance and strength. | Extremely heavy and highly expensive. Primarily reserved for Navy and high-performance reactors.         |

Table 1: Common Control Rod Materials in Thermal Reactors

## 6.1 The Helium Gas Problem ( $B_4C$ )

Boron is a fantastic absorber, but the B-10 reaction is:



Over years of operation, a Boron control rod slowly fills with Helium gas. If the internal pressure exceeds the strength of the stainless steel cladding, the rod can swell, deform, and become physically stuck inside the core. To prevent this,  $B_4C$  rods are built with hollow "plena" (empty tube sections at the top) to give the gas room to expand.

## 6.2 The Hafnium Advantage

Unlike Boron or AIC, Hafnium is a refractory metal with chemical properties almost identical to Zirconium. It does not swell, and it does not corrode in high-temperature water. Consequently, Hafnium control blades do not need protective stainless steel cladding; they can be machined as solid metal components. Furthermore, when Hf-177 absorbs a neutron, it becomes Hf-178, which is *also* an excellent neutron absorber. This "chain-absorbing" property gives Hafnium an exceptionally long operational lifespan, making it the material of choice for nuclear submarines where refueling is exceptionally difficult.

# 7 Mechanical Design and Flux Shaping Strategies

How we physically shape and insert these absorbing materials depends on the thermal-hydraulic design of the reactor. Furthermore, engineers must account for what happens to the localized neutron flux when a rod is withdrawn.

- **PWR "Spider" Assemblies:** In a Pressurized Water Reactor (PWR), the water is a single-phase liquid. Control rods are bundled into clusters of roughly 24 thin rodlets attached to a central hub (a "spider"). These drop directly into hollow guide thimbles integrated into the fuel assembly lattice from above.
- **BWR Cruciform Blades:** In a Boiling Water Reactor (BWR), the fuel assemblies are enclosed in solid metal channel boxes to prevent boiling cross-flow. Therefore, BWRs use **cruciform (cross-shaped)** blades that slide into the gaps *between* four adjacent assemblies. They are driven hydraulically from the **bottom** to avoid the steam-drying equipment at the top of the vessel.
- **Flux Shaping and "Grey Rods":** Commercial reactors do not want severe, localized power spikes when rods are moved. To manage the axial power distribution smoothly:
  - **Axial Grading:** The absorber material is often varied along the length of the rod. The tip may contain a weaker absorber (or a lower enrichment of B-10) than the main body to "soften" the neutron shadow and prevent a sharp power peak in the fuel immediately below the rod.
  - **Grey Rods:** Advanced PWRs utilize specialized "Grey Rods." Unlike standard "Black Rods" designed to heavily absorb neutrons and shut the reactor down, grey rods use weaker absorbing materials (like Inconel or stainless steel). They are used purely to gently shape the axial flux profile and control Xenon transients without causing massive local flux depressions.

- **Follower Rods (Research & Test Reactors):** In high-flux test reactors, pulling a solid control rod out of the core leaves an empty channel that immediately fills with water. This sudden block of pure moderator causes a dangerous localized thermal flux spike. To prevent this, rods are built with "followers"—a solid section of low-absorbing material (like aluminum or beryllium) attached to the bottom of the absorber. As the absorber is pulled up, the follower slides into the core to displace the water and keep the moderation profile perfectly flat.
- **The Fatal Flaw: RBMK Graphite Tips & Slow SCRAMs:** The concept of a "follower" rod was disastrously misapplied in the Soviet RBMK-1000 (Chernobyl).
  - To improve fuel efficiency, Soviet engineers attached 4.5-meter graphite "displacers" to the bottom of their boron control rods.
  - **The "Positive SCRAM":** When a fully withdrawn rod was ordered to SCRAM, the graphite tip entered the lower core first, displacing the light water (which acted as a mild neutron poison in the graphite moderated RBMK). The reactor temporarily replaced a poison with a fantastic moderator (graphite), creating a significant **positive reactivity insertion**.
  - **Slow Insertion Speed:** Western control rods drop via gravity in 2 to 4 seconds. The RBMK rods were motor-driven and took **18 to 20 seconds** to fully insert. This painfully slow insertion meant the graphite tips sat in the active core adding positive reactivity for several seconds, triggering a prompt critical explosion before the boron absorber could reach the high-flux region of the core.

## 8 Summary

- **Non-Linearity:** Control rods are not linear dials; their worth scales with the local flux squared ( $\phi^2$ ).
- **Differential Worth:** Follows a chopped  $\sin^2(z)$  shape, peaking exactly in the center of the core.
- **Integral Worth:** Follows an S-Curve.
- **Shadowing:** Rods influence the worth of other rods by squishing and pushing the spatial neutron flux.
- **Calibration:** Conducted carefully using the Reactor Period measurement.

## References

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